MODULE 16 · DOMAIN 1 - PEOPLE

Knowledge transfer

Finding the knowledge the project depends on, capturing and sharing it, and building a team where sharing is normal.

DOMAIN I - People EXAM WEIGHT 33% MODULE 16 of 49

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Knowledge that lives in one head leaves when that person does.

Explicit or tacit knowledge?

EXPLICIT KNOWLEDGE

Can be written down

- Facts, procedures, specifications
- Documents, diagrams, data
- Easy to store and search
- Transferred by documenting

TACIT KNOWLEDGE

Hard to write down

- Experience, judgement, intuition
- Know-how, context, relationships
- Lives in people
- Transferred by working together

THE TIEBREAKER

Tacit knowledge is not transferred by writing more documents. It moves through people working side by side.

Identifying critical knowledge

- Ask: **what would stop the project** if one particular person were unavailable tomorrow?
- Look for **single points of knowledge**: the only person who understands a system, a supplier, a regulation.
- Record key-person dependency as a **risk**, with a response.
- Act early, while the person is still available and not under pressure.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Key-person dependency is a risk. Identify it early and respond before it becomes an issue.

Ways to transfer knowledge

FOR EXPLICIT KNOWLEDGE	FOR TACIT KNOWLEDGE
Documentation, wikis, runbooks	Pairing and shadowing
Decision logs and design records	Mentoring and coaching
Lessons learned register	Communities of practice
Knowledge repositories and search	Workshops, storytelling, demonstrations
Training materials and recordings	Job rotation and joint problem-solving

ON THE EXAM

Match the method to the knowledge. Documents for facts; people for judgement.

The lessons learned register

- Started **early**, and updated **throughout** the project, not just at the end.
- Records what happened, its impact, and a **specific recommendation**.
- Fed by retrospectives, reviews, issue resolution and risk responses.
- 'Communication could have been better' is not a lesson. 'Confirm supplier specs in writing with examples' is.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Lessons are captured as they happen, and applied during the project, not saved for a final meeting.

Lessons learned register or repository?

REGISTER

This project

- Created and used during the project
- Owned by the project team
- Applied to current work
- Updated continuously

REPOSITORY

The organisation

- Holds lessons from many projects
- An organisational process asset
- Searched at the start of new projects
- Receives the register at phase or project end

THE TIEBREAKER

The register is for this project. At phase or project end, lessons move to the repository for everyone else.

Using lessons, not just collecting them

- At the **start** of a project, search the repository and talk to people who ran similar work.
- In **planning**, turn relevant lessons into risks, estimates and process choices.
- In **retrospectives**, check whether last time's improvements were actually applied.
- A repository nobody searches is an archive, not knowledge transfer.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The value of a lesson is realised only when someone uses it. Search first, then plan.

Fostering an environment for sharing

- **Psychological safety**: people share mistakes and uncertainties only when that is safe.
- **Time**: make knowledge sharing part of the plan, not something done after hours.
- **Recognition**: celebrate people who teach, document and help others.
- **Easy tools**: one searchable place, simple templates.
- People hoard knowledge when being the only expert feels like job security.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Hoarding is usually a response to fear. Remove the fear, and reward sharing.

Handovers

- **People leaving**: plan an overlap, pair them with a successor, record key decisions and contacts.
- **Suppliers exiting**: knowledge transfer written into the contract, with acceptance criteria.
- **Transition to operations**: runbooks, training, shadowing, and support during early live running.
- Start every handover **early**, and confirm the receiver can actually do the work.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A handover is complete when the receiver can do the work, not when the documents are delivered.

Communities of practice

- Groups of people who share a discipline or interest, across teams and projects.
- Testers, data engineers, project managers, Scrum masters, all learning from each other.
- Spread tacit knowledge and good practice beyond any single project.
- Especially useful on scaled agile work, where specialists are spread across many teams.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Communities of practice carry knowledge between projects, which is exactly where it is usually lost.

AI and project knowledge

- AI search and summaries can make large repositories genuinely usable.
- AI can draft meeting notes, decision records and first versions of documentation.
- Verify accuracy, and respect **confidentiality and data privacy** before feeding in project data.
- AI can move explicit knowledge. Tacit knowledge still moves through people.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Use AI to make explicit knowledge findable. Check its output, and protect sensitive data.

Project Lantern: keeping knowledge in the project

- Only one analyst understood the **old booking system's data**. A colleague now pairs with her on every migration run.
- The first clinic's go-live lessons became a **checklist** used by the next five.
- The kiosk supplier's contract includes **knowledge transfer** to Northgate's IT team, with a sign-off.
- At each phase end, the register's lessons go to Northgate's **repository**.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Critical knowledge identified, gathered, shared and passed on. All three outline enablers in one project.

Scenario signals and the move

THE SCENARIO SAYS	THE MOVE
Only one person knows a critical system	Key-person risk: pairing and documentation now
New project resembles a past one	Search the repository; talk to its team
Expert know-how will not go into manuals	Tacit: shadowing, pairing, mentoring
Project or phase closing	Move the register's lessons to the repository
People keep knowledge to themselves	Safety, time and recognition for sharing
Supplier or team member leaving	Planned handover, confirmed by the receiver

ON THE EXAM

Identify, gather, share, and never let critical knowledge depend on one person.

> Only one engineer understands how a project's legacy billing interface works. She starts parental leave in two months.
>
> The interface must be changed during the final phase of the project, four months from now.

What should the project manager do?

A Ask her to postpone her leave until the interface work is complete.

B Plan to hire a specialist contractor once she has gone.

C Arrange for her to be available by phone during her leave.

D Treat it as a key-person risk: pair a colleague with her now, and document the interface together.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Ask her to postpone leave.

Inappropriate, and possibly unlawful. The knowledge problem is the project's, not hers.

B Hire a contractor afterwards.

Nobody left to learn from. The contractor starts from zero.

C On call during leave.

Intrudes on protected leave and leaves the dependency in place.

D Key-person risk: pair and document now.

Uses the two months available to move both tacit and explicit knowledge.

THE SIGNAL

A known departure date plus one expert: transfer now, while there is time and the person is available.

> A project manager is starting a project to open a new regional distribution centre. The organisation opened a similar centre in another region eighteen months ago.
>
> The project manager is about to begin planning.

What should the project manager do first?

A. Review the earlier project's lessons in the repository, and talk to people who worked on it.

B. Start planning from scratch, since every region is different.

C. Wait until problems arise, then ask the previous team for advice.

D. Ask the new team to share what they remember hearing about the earlier project.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do first?

A Review lessons; talk to the previous team.

Uses organisational knowledge before planning, when it is most valuable.

B Plan from scratch.

Ignores eighteen months of directly relevant experience.

C Ask when problems arise.

Reactive. The point is to avoid repeating the problems.

D Rely on second-hand memories.

Hearsay instead of the recorded lessons and the people who were there.

THE SIGNAL

A similar past project and planning about to start: search the repository and talk to the people first.

A senior technician diagnoses complex machine faults quickly, often from the sound a machine makes. He retires in six months.

Two attempts to capture his knowledge in manuals produced long documents that the junior technicians find unhelpful.

What should the project manager do?

A Ask him to write a more detailed manual with more diagrams.

B Record a series of video lectures in which he explains his methods.

C Have junior technicians shadow and pair with him on real faults over the coming months.

D Hold a detailed exit interview with him before he retires.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A. A more detailed manual.
The third attempt at a method that has already failed twice.

B. Video lectures.
Better than text, but still one-way. Judgement is learned by doing.

C. Shadowing and pairing on real faults.
Tacit knowledge moves through people working side by side.

D. An exit interview.
One conversation, at the last moment, cannot transfer years of intuition.

THE SIGNAL

Knowledge that will not go into manuals is tacit. Move it through shadowing and pairing.

> A project has reached closure. Its lessons learned register contains thirty specific lessons gathered throughout the project.
>
> The project manager is completing the closing activities.

What should happen to the lessons learned?

A They should be archived with the rest of the project files.

B They should be transferred into the organisation's lessons learned repository.

C They should be deleted, since the project is over.

D They should be emailed to the project team as a record.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should happen to the lessons learned?

A. Archive with project files.
Stored, but not findable. Future projects will not look there.

B. Transfer to the organisational repository.
Turns project lessons into an organisational process asset others can search.

C. Delete them.
Throws away exactly what the organisation needs to improve.

D. Email them to the team.
Reaches people who already know them, and nobody else.

THE SIGNAL

At closure, the register's lessons move to the organisation's repository, an organisational process asset.

> In a cost-cutting year, several team members have become reluctant to share how they do their work. One says privately that being 'the only one who knows' is the best protection against redundancy.
>
> Knowledge sharing sessions are poorly attended.

What should the project manager do?

A Address the fear, make time for sharing in the plan, and visibly recognise people who share.

B Make documentation mandatory, with penalties for anyone who does not comply.

C Rotate team members into each other's roles without warning, to force sharing.

D Report the reluctant team members to their functional managers.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Address the fear; time; recognition.

Fosters the environment for sharing, which is the outline's third enabler.

B Mandatory documentation with penalties.

Adds a second fear to the first. Compliance, not sharing.

C Surprise rotations.

Confirms that the project sees people as replaceable. Deepens the fear.

D Report them.

Punishes a rational response to a real fear.

THE SIGNAL

Hoarding driven by fear: address the fear and reward sharing. Penalties make it worse.

> A supplier's contract to run a new customer platform ends in one month. The supplier's engineers hold most of the operational know-how.
>
> The organisation's own operations team must take over running the platform when the contract ends.

What should the project manager do?

A Ask the supplier to send its documentation after the contract ends.

B Extend the supplier's contract indefinitely to avoid the risk.

C Let the operations team learn the platform once they take it over.

D Agree a structured handover: joint sessions, runbooks and shadowing, with operations confirming readiness.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Documents after the contract ends.

Too late, with no leverage, and documents alone miss the tacit part.

B Extend indefinitely.

Avoids the handover rather than doing it, at open-ended cost.

C Learn after takeover.

Operations learns by failing in front of customers.

D Structured handover, readiness confirmed.

Moves explicit and tacit knowledge, and ends when operations can run it.

THE SIGNAL

A handover is finished when the receiver can do the work. Structure it, and let the receiver confirm.

Find the critical knowledge. Move it the right way. **Never depend on one head.**